

Opioid overdose: recognize it, reverse it

An opioid overdose slows or stops a person's breathing. **Naloxone** is a medicine that can quickly reverse it. It only works on opioids, it is not addictive, and giving it to someone who is *not* overdosing will not harm them — so when in doubt, use it.

CALL EMERGENCY SERVICES FIRST

Always call for help

If you think someone is overdosing, call your local emergency number (911 in the US/Canada, 112 in much of Europe, 999 in the UK) **right away**, then give naloxone. Naloxone can wear off before the opioids do, so professional help is still needed even if the person wakes up.

Know the signs of an overdose

WARNING SIGNS

- Will not wake up or respond to your voice or touch
- Breathing is very slow, shallow, or has stopped
- Gurgling, gasping, or snoring/choking sounds
- Lips, fingertips, or skin turning blue, gray, or pale
- Very small, "pinpoint" pupils
- Limp body; cold or clammy skin

To check responsiveness, call their name, then firmly rub your knuckles on their breastbone. If they don't respond, treat it as an overdose.

What to do — step by step

- 1 Call emergency services.** Report that someone is unresponsive and not breathing normally, and give your location.
 - 2 Give naloxone.** For nasal spray (e.g. Narcan): tilt the head back, insert the nozzle into one nostril until your fingers touch the bottom of their nose, and press the plunger firmly all the way in.
 - 3 Support their breathing.** If you are trained, give rescue breaths. Otherwise, keep their airway clear.
 - 4 Wait 2–3 minutes.** If there is no improvement (still not breathing or not awake), give a **second dose** in the other nostril.
 - 5 Put them in the recovery position.** Once breathing, lay them on their side so they don't choke if they vomit.
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- 6 Stay with them** until emergency help arrives. Naloxone can wear off in 30–90 minutes and the overdose can return.

GOOD TO KNOW

- **Naloxone is safe.** It only reverses opioids and will not hurt someone who has not taken opioids. There is no harm in giving it "just in case."
- **It is widely available.** In the U.S., naloxone nasal spray is approved for over-the-counter sale and is free or low-cost through many pharmacies, health departments, and harm-reduction programs. Availability varies by country — ask a local pharmacist or health service.
- **Withdrawal may follow.** Naloxone can cause sudden, uncomfortable opioid withdrawal (sweating, nausea, agitation). This is not dangerous in itself, but reassure the person and keep them safe.
- **Many overdoses involve fentanyl**, a very strong opioid. A second dose of naloxone is often needed — do not hesitate to give it.

GOOD SAMARITAN PROTECTIONS

Many places have "Good Samaritan" laws that protect people who call for help during an overdose from certain drug-possession charges. Protections vary by location — but **calling for help is always the right thing to do**. A life comes first.

Be prepared before an emergency

- Carry naloxone if you or someone you know uses opioids (including prescription painkillers).
- Ask a pharmacist or local health department how to get it and how to use your specific product.
- Tell the people around you where your naloxone is kept.
- Encourage people not to use alone; if they do, ask them to tell someone or use a "never use alone" hotline where available.

Sources

- U.S. Substance Abuse and Mental Health Services Administration (SAMHSA) — *Opioid Overdose Prevention Toolkit* and naloxone guidance. [samhsa.gov](https://www.samhsa.gov)
- U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) — *Lifesaving Naloxone and Preventing Opioid Overdose*. [cdc.gov/overdose-prevention](https://www.cdc.gov/overdose-prevention)
- U.S. National Institute on Drug Abuse (NIDA) — *Naloxone DrugFacts*. [nida.nih.gov](https://www.nida.nih.gov)
- U.S. Food and Drug Administration (FDA) — over-the-counter approval of naloxone nasal spray (2023). [fda.gov](https://www.fda.gov)

Steps reflect SAMHSA/CDC overdose-response guidance. Always follow the instructions printed on your specific naloxone product, and your local emergency services' direction.

This guide is general information, not medical advice, and is not a substitute for professional emergency care or training. In an emergency, always call your local emergency number. Hands-on naloxone and rescue-breathing training is widely available and recommended. Reuse and reprint freely.